The conservation effort showed that the Qutb Shahis had independently evolved the formal funerary gardens, without Mughal influence. Major conservation works included removal of the 20th century cement plaster, restoration of missing and damaged stucco patterns, replacement of missing stone elements and removal of tonnes of concrete from the domes of monuments. A significant discovery was of the remnants of green glazed tiles on the dome of the mausoleum of Mohammad Qutb Shah (ruled 1612-26). It was restored with tiles produced by craftsmen at the Humayun's Tomb site, who had earlier been trained by ceramics experts from Uzbekistan.

"It required over a decade to meticulously conserve, restore, even reconstruct each of the monuments–small or grand–with craftsmen clocking over a million days of work," says Nanda. He is confident this will serve as a showcase model for an integrated landscape restoration and a craft-based building conservation effort by uniting public and private agencies, including those promoting tourism, to secure threatened heritage.



Celebrating a Landmark Effort
Telangana CM A. Revanth Reddy inaugurating the Qutb Shahi Heritage Park with AKTC director-general Luis Monreal (left) and Rahim Aga Khan in Hyderabad, July 28

While AKTC remained the mainstay, others, including diplomatic missions, funded portions of the massive conservation process. Tata Trusts provided funding for nine major monuments, and the US Ambassadors Fund for Cultural Preservation extended grants for archaeological excavations for the conservation of the Taramati and Premamati tombs and the five stepwells. The German embassy funded work on three monuments and the Indigo Reach and Inter Globe Foundation supported the conservation of Muhammad Qutb Shah's tomb. "QSHP has shown how conservation can be done with the same genre of material used originally and with similar craftsmanship," says Sajjad Shahid, a civil engineer and convenor, Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage (INTACH).

There were challenges, too, other than those of pure restoration. Administrative issues slowed the pace of restoration, while lands belonging to two different government agencies—the Deccan Park with the Quli Qutb Shah Urban Development Authority and the core archaeological zone with the state archaeology department—posed challenges. Interventions by the Telangana government helped remove roadblocks. The sustained interest of the AKTC and its chairman, the Aga Khan, who called for quarterly reports and visited the site thrice, ensured its steady progress.

"AKTC will continue to assist the department of heritage of the Telangana government to manage the site at least till December 2025—though we are in discussion to establish a management system for 10 years—as with the Sunder Nursery Management Trust in Delhi," says Nanda. It is committed to helping complete the site museum at the QSHP where construction has been stalled due to litigation.

Vying for a UNESCO world heritage site status for the QSHP is on the cards. But that will not be enough. "The public private partnership that brought about this massive project should ensure its sustainability through the park's future management. The goal has to be to draw visitors by providing high quality services," says AKTC general manager Luis Monreal. Else, it may be reduced to what it was—a pit stop for visiting foreign dignitaries that began with the Shah of Iran in 1978. The untarnished magnificence of the heritage park is for common citizens to visit and take pride in. ■